

assigning a password to the bootloader (Grub, in most cases today, or LILO, short for Linux Loader—mostly older versions)

To setup Grub such that it asks for a password to edit the boot configuration, do this:

Go to the command shell and type :

md5crypt

When asked for a password, supply your root password, single user mode gives you root privileges.

You will then get an encrypted version of the password you have supplied. Now copy this encrypted password and add it to the grub configuration file, that is */etc/grub.conf*

Edit the file using *vi* or any editor or a command such as

Cat >> /etc/grub.conf

When you use the above command the shell will wait for your input. Now type “*password -md5*” followed by a space, just copy paste the encrypted password. Press *[Enter]*.

When you open the file in any editor, make the *password -md5 <encrypted password>* line as the first line and save the file.

Now, when you reboot and try to edit the boot configuration to enter as single user mode, you will be asked for the password that you have just set! (which we have suggested you keep the same as root password, but you can have any password actually).

So far, so good. We have seen how to setup a BIOS password and prevent unauthorised single user entry. But what if someone boots your computer with some other device? Like say, an attacker using his own CD-ROM or hard disk to boot your machine... he can use a Live CD or, mount the file system and make alterations. How would you prevent this? Well, advanced system administrators would store their password configuration files on a server or in the desktop itself, but not in the obvious default location. But we are not addressing people who know computers better than the back of their hands.

As a common computer user, you can password protect your sensitive documents. OpenOffice.org provides an option to password